

Thomas Hobbes: man as machine



Thomas Hobbes took an active interest in the scientific discoveries of the 17th century. He corresponded regularly with mathematicians including Descartes, but came to very different conclusions. Prompted by the debate over Cartesian mind–body dualism, he declared himself an outright materialist, dismissing the concept of ‘immaterial substance’ as a contradiction in terms (a brave declaration at a time when belief in God was still virtually compulsory). Everything in the universe is physical or material, and nothing exists outside it.

Influenced by the astronomy of Copernicus and Galileo, Hobbes took a mechanistic view of the workings of the universe, arguing that even humans could be considered as machines subject to physical laws. He was especially intrigued by Galileo's theories of motion and impetus, which he believed explained not only the behaviour of our bodies, but also our mental activity. Our minds, he argued, are physical 'machines', and our psychology is ruled by the same physical laws as everything else in the universe.